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HIGH SCHOOL ROUNDUP

Warriors, Bears nip district foes

From staff reports

Two dramatic endings highlighted Saturday's area girls basketball district-championship action.

In the Division II showdown at Brocksville-Bronxview Heights, top-seeded Trinity missed two free throws in the final seconds, giving second-seeded Walsh Jesuit a 64-63 victory and the Lady Warriors their fifth consecutive district crown.

At the Medina Division I final, junior forward Katie Mastrodonato hit a driving shot in the lane with 4.5 seconds remaining, leading North Royalton past Pioneer Conference rival Strongsville, 44-43. Mastrodonato's game-winning spin around the back before giving the Lady Bears (17-6) their first regional appearance in Division I.

Trinity (21-2) outscored Walsh, 20-14, in the third quarter and took a two-point lead into the final eight minutes.

The Lady Trojans, who got a game-high 28 points from All-Ohio junior post Rachele Hitz, tied the score at 63 on a 3-pointer by junior guard Dindra Bremond. Walsh (21-3) then made one of two free throws before Trinity came up short in its final attempts.

At Medina, Mastrodonato finished with a game-high 14 points and was supported by 11 points and six assists from senior point guard Megan Wydra. Strongsville (17-6), which outscored North Royalton, 14-4, in the fourth quarter, tied the score at 40 on consecutive 3-pointers by Lexi Sparrow with 4:40 left.

Hathaway Brown 50, Berkshire 37 Despite losing point guard Lizzy Scully (broken nose) in the first quarter, the Division III Blazers (13-10) captured their first district basketball championship. HIB got 17-point performances from senior Antoinette Eldemire and freshman Angela Groves.

Elyria 46, Magnificat 39 Led by all-state senior guard Kate Verhoff's 24 points, the Pioneers (22-1) brought home their second consecutive Westlake Division I district crown. Magnificat (9-15) led by one point entering the final eight minutes, but Elyria hit 11 of 17 free throws in the fourth quarter.

Mentor 56, Glenville 53 Behind 32 points by All-Ohio senior post Megan Skouby, the Cardinals turned back the fourth-quarter charge by the Tarbolours in the Perry Division I title game.

Basketball

Walsh Jesuit 60, Orange 43 Dwayne Jackson, Walsh Jesuit's leading career scorer with 1,318 points, grabbed nine rebounds against the Lions in this Division II sectional final and became the Warriors' career leader in that category with 700.

Wooster 58, Wadsworth 56 Junior Logan Walker made two free throws with 15.6 seconds remaining, and Wadsworth failed to get off a final shot as the fourth-seeded Generals (15-7) foiled the Grizzlies in a Division I sectional title game. Wadsworth (11-11) had a 16-point lead in the first quarter but failed to maintain its early momentum.

Hockey

Shaker Heights 4, Lake Catholic 2 After defeating the Cougars for third time in four meetings this season, the Raiders have earned their 10th trip to the state finals.

In capturing the Kent State district crown, Shaker Heights (23-7) advanced to a state semifinal matchup with the Sylvania district champion on March 5 at 10 a.m. at Nationwide Arena in Columbus.

Nate Bixenstien showed the way by scoring two of his team's three second-period goals. He also assisted on a goal by Jeff Musser with four seconds remaining. Brandon Hemmelgarn chipped in with a goal and an assist as the Raiders came back from a 1-0 deficit.

GIRLS BASKETBALL DIVISION I DISTRICT FINALS

Stow, JFK win with solid play

No. 2 Stow 51, No. 3 Barborton 39 Perched on a ladder, Stow coach Bob Podes clipped the last strand of net and turned to his team huddled below on the Ellet gymnasium floor.

"This is for each and every one of you," Podes said to his players, as he ripped the net from the basket during the traditional ritual that follows championship games.

It was the first time in school history that a girls coach from Stow was able to cut down nets. Podes' team turned in perhaps its most impressive performance of the season in front of a packed house of about 1,400 fans in the Division I title game by defeating its conference rival for the second time in three meetings. Stow (23-1) will play Cleveland John F. Kennedy in a regional semifinal on Tuesday at 6:15 p.m. in the Canton Civic Center.

"Amazing," is how Stow senior Sarah Drabinski described the victory, as she twirled her personal piece of net. "We were totally focused. We came in on top of our game, and we were totally focused the entire time, and you could see it down the stretch."

Drabinski scored 14 points and had eight rebounds but was not alone as the Lady Bulldogs' defense harassed Barborton into a 13 of 39 shooting night from the field. Senior guard Carly

Hawkins led all scorers with 16 points, and sophomore guard Liana Jennings played one of her best games of the season with 14 points, six rebounds, three steals and one blocked shot.

Stow held all-Ohioan Shana Andrus to 11 points and point guard Brittany Mingo to six. The Lady Magics (21-3) made just 9 of 20 free-throw attempts.

Stow, ranked second in The Plain Dealer Top 25 and third in Ohio, took control with a 10-4 spurt to start the third quarter, extending a 25-21 halftime lead. The lead eventually reached 11 points late in the third before the Lady Magics, ranked third by The Plain Dealer and fifth in Ohio, cut it to five, 44-39, with 1:44 to go. Drabinski increased the lead with a layup, and Hawkins made it 48-39 with two free throws with 56.2 seconds left following a technical foul on Olivia Williams for throwing a shield.

—Tim Rogers

No. 18 JFK 52, No. 19 Solon 40 The top-seeded John F. Kennedy girls used an 11-0 run at the outset of the second quarter as a springboard, then finished with a 15 of 16 effort from the free-throw line in the fourth quarter for a Division I district basketball title game victory over No. 2-seeded Solon.

Nominate top players

Coaches' nominations for boys basketball Players of the Week will be accepted today between 11 a.m. and 2 p.m. The toll-free number for coaches to call for the seven-county coverage area is 1-800-388-4370. The local number is 216-999-4370.

Final basketball stats due

Boys and girls basketball coaches are asked to report their final regular-season statistical leaders to The Plain Dealer. The deadline is 11 p.m. Monday. This can be done by e-mail (results@pland.com), fax (216-999-6276) or phone (216-999-4370) after 9 p.m. The final installment will run later this week. Categories are: points, rebounds, assists, steals and 3-pointers made.

Test helps to remove questions on prospect

JODIE VALADE
Plain Dealer Reporter

Michael Callans swears he doesn't usually cause men to quake at his mere sight. After all, he stands only about 5-7.

But when he visits the NFL scouting combine in Indianapolis, draft prospects sometimes sweat and quiver.

"They look at me as though I'm some kind of terminator," Callans said, chuckling. "Anywhere else, they wouldn't think twice. But this is part of the game that scares them the most."

Callans is the president of consulting for Wonderlic, the company that administers the Wonderlic Personnel Test each year to potential NFL draftees. The test that measures intelligence and problem-solving abilities has been a staple of the combine evaluation process for the past 20 years, after originally gaining popularity as an assessment tool used by the Dallas Cowboys.

Players have 12 minutes to take the 50-question test. The test is designed, Callans said, for the average person to get half the questions right, and to attempt only 35 questions in the short time frame.

"You can't really study for it," Callans said. "It happens so fast. We don't give out any tips for it, and there isn't a Kaplan course on how to take it."

Still, agents often prep players for the test, giving them practice exams and SAT-like tips. Questions vary from complex word problems to simple fill-in-the-blank statements.

Callans said that the test has changed little over the years. An average person in any industry scores a 21 out of a possible 50. An average NFL player scores 19. Among football players, a good score for a quarterback is a 25, Callans said. Quarterbacks and centers, players that handle the ball on every snap, typically score highest. A

A taste of the Wonderlic test

The Wonderlic is a 50-question test that must be completed in 12 minutes. Here are a handful of sample questions:

1. RESENT RESERVE — Do these words...

A) have similar meanings
B) have contradictory meanings
C) mean neither the same or opposite

2. When rope is selling at \$.10 a foot, how many feet can you buy for sixty cents?

3. The ninth month of the year is:
A) October.
B) January.
C) June.
D) September.
E) May.

4. Which number in the following group of numbers represents the smallest amount?
A) 7
B) .8
C) 1
D) .33
E) 2

5. A train travels 20 feet in one-fifth of a second. At this same speed, how many feet will it travel in three seconds?
ANSWERS:
1. C
2. 6 feet
3. D
4. D
5. 300

good score for a defensive lineman, a position that demands fewer decision-making instances, would be 18-19, Callans said.

Only one NFL player — former Cincinnati Bengals punter Pat McInally, who came to the league via Harvard — has received a perfect score. Last year's No. 1 selection, quarterback Eli Manning, recorded a 39.

To reach this Plain Dealer reporter: jvalade@pland.com, 216-999-4654

MIND

FROM C1 Cleveland teams delve into players' traits

Gone are the days when an athlete would be evaluated by physical ability alone. In every sport in every pre-draft event, athletes are dissected and prodded into answering questions that rate intelligence and categorical personalities. Professional teams — and an increasing number of colleges — use personality and intelligence assessments to categorize athletes. In the high-priced world of sports, teams want to make sure they're investing in a player who won't self-destruct under their watch.

Every team has its own philosophy on what test provides the best analysis of personality, intelligence and competitive nature, and what combination of mental qualities might yield a superstar. In Cleveland, the Indians and Cavaliers use Charles Maher as a team psychologist. The Rutgers psychology professor administers the 16 PF test among his four-level assessment plan that creates a mental profile of each player.

The Browns, under the direction of new General Manager Phil Savage, take a research-oriented approach that combines personal interviews with results from the NFL-administered Wonderlic Personnel Test given to all players at the NFL scouting combine. That test, which was given during the combine that began Wednesday and ends today, measures intelligence and serves as an additional assessment tool for all teams.

The results that label personality characteristics and flaws before a draft or trade sometimes can mean the difference between taking a chance on a player and letting him slip by.

"We're in the information age, and the more information you can have, the better decisions you can make," said Jim Paxson, the Cavaliers' general manager.

That's why the Cavaliers hired Maher, a relationship that developed after he began working with the Indians in 1996. Maher maintains a database of information on 40,000 basketball and baseball players. Each profile contains an analysis of the player's personality and intelligence, attained from a four-

part assessment plan Maher uses.

Maher's assessment plan consists of:

■ Personality assessment. Every athlete is given the 16 PF, a 30-minute test that identifies and gauges qualities such as reasoning, emotional stability, sensitivity, self-reliance and perfectionism.

■ Assessment of the ability to cope with risks. Athletes are interviewed to determine personal and family history, and exposure to troublesome people, places and addictive substances.

■ Assessment as a teammate. Information obtained from the 16 PF test is combined with background interviews from scouts and other players/teammates.

■ Assessment as a performer. A player's test results are compared to others in the database, and each athlete is rated in situations where he feels confident and less self-assured.

From information learned in each of those levels, Maher then tags each player with a green, amber or red flag. That lets the Cavaliers and Indians know what kind of risk is involved with each player.

Maher stressed that he never tells a team not to draft or trade for a player; just that some players, tagged with a red flag, are "high-maintenance" and will need additional attention.

"The more important thing is telling teams, 'Here's what that might mean down the line in terms of helping a player,'" Maher said.

Browns General Manager Savage will rely on in-person interviews conducted by himself and head coach Romeo Crennel. The Browns don't employ a team psychologist and don't administer tests beyond the Wonderlic. Savage said he used a psychologist in his early days at Baltimore, but over the years, the team simplified the evaluation process.

"I'm not necessarily that big on that sort of testing," Savage said. "I don't know...it's football. It's not quite as hard as some people make it out to be."

All the Cleveland team executives stress that they're not searching for a specific personality or intelligence, just the right blend of qualities for a team to work successfully.

To reach this Plain Dealer reporter: jvalade@pland.com, 216-999-4654

HIGH SCHOOL SCOREBOARD

BOYS BASKETBALL

Sectional finals

SATURNIA'S SCORES

Division II

Boardman 56, Northview 37

Poland 68, You. Wilson 35

Canton 44, Northview 36

Stow 44, Northview 36

Alon North 59, Warrensville 57

Walsh Jesuit 60, Orange 43

Brecksville 75, Southview 61

OT: Talmadge 61, Streetsboro 46

Division III

Eastland 40, Gilmour 63

Perry 46, Westlake 33

Westlake 40, Westlake 33

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